Week 9: Subject Analysis

Introduction

Subject analysis is one of the most important intellectual activities in knowledge organisation. Before any information resource can be classified or catalogued, its **subject content** must first be determined. Subject analysis is therefore the foundation upon which classification and indexing are built.

It involves examining the content of a book, article, or any information-bearing material to determine *what it is about*. Once the subject has been identified, it can then be represented by classification numbers, subject headings, or descriptors that accurately reflect its content.

Definition of Subject Analysis

Several scholars have defined subject analysis in slightly different ways:

Aina (2004) defines subject analysis as *the process of examining the intellectual content of a document to determine its subject and the appropriate representation of that subject in a classification system or subject heading list.*

Oso and Onifade (2010) describe it as *the process of determining the subject or subjects of a document so that it can be classified and retrieved when needed.*

In simple terms, **subject analysis** is the process of *deciding what a document is about and representing it in a way that facilitates retrieval*.

Importance of Subject Analysis

Subject analysis plays a vital role in library operations and information retrieval. Some key reasons include:

a. Foundation for Classification

Without knowing the subject of a document, you cannot assign the correct class number or shelf mark. Subject analysis is therefore the first step before classification.

b. Supports Accurate Cataloguing

During cataloguing, subject analysis ensures that the right subject headings or descriptors are used, allowing users to find materials under relevant topics in the catalogue.

c. Enhances Information Retrieval

When done properly, subject analysis ensures that users retrieve *relevant* materials, not just items that happen to share similar words in their titles.

d. Saves Time and Effort

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Accurate subject analysis helps prevent misclassification, which could cause materials to be misplaced or overlooked during searches.

e. Promotes Knowledge Organisation

It helps libraries and information centres maintain a systematic arrangement of resources, reflecting the relationships between subjects and disciplines.

Steps in Subject Analysis

To perform effective subject analysis, librarians or cataloguers follow systematic steps:

Step 1: Examine the Document

Read or scan the document carefully — check the **title, table of contents, introduction, summary, preface, and chapter headings**. These sections often reveal the key topics covered.

Step 2: Identify the Main Subject

Determine the **central idea or theme**. Ask: "What is this document primarily about?" Focus on the main subject rather than secondary or minor ones.

Step 3: Identify Secondary or Related Subjects

Many materials deal with more than one aspect. Identify additional concepts or subjects that are closely related to the main topic.

Step 4: Choose Specific Terms

Select precise subject terms that describe the content accurately. For example, instead of "Education," you might use "Adult Education" or "Distance Learning."

Step 5: Verify Terms in a Standard Tool

Check your chosen terms in an authorised tool like:

1. *Library of Congress Subject Headings (LCSH)*
2. *Sears List of Subject Headings*
3. *Thesauri and indexes in specialised fields.*

Step 6: Assign Classification Numbers

After confirming the subject, select the appropriate **class number** from a classification scheme (e.g., DDC, LCC) that best represents the subject.

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Factors to Consider During Subject Analysis

When analysing subjects, certain factors must be kept in mind:

a. Purpose of the Document

Ask why the document was written. A book on "Using Computers in Education" focuses on the *application* of technology, not on general computer science.

b. Intended Audience

Materials for children, professionals, or researchers may differ in scope and emphasis.

c. Scope and Coverage

Determine how broad or narrow the topic is. A broad work like "African Literature" differs from a specific one like "Contemporary Nigerian Poetry."

d. Point of View

Some works present a specific perspective, e.g., "Feminist Approaches to History" focuses on gender interpretation, not history in general.

e. Language and Terminology

Ensure that subject terms are consistent with library standards (e.g., use "Information Technology," not "Computer Studies," if that's the accepted term).

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Tools for Subject Analysis

To ensure uniformity and accuracy, librarians rely on recognised reference tools and standards:

Tool	Purpose
Library of Congress Subject Headings (LCSH)	Provides standard subject headings for cataloguing.
Sears List of Subject Headings	Designed for smaller libraries.
Thesauri (e.g., UNESCO Thesaurus)	Lists controlled vocabulary terms and relationships among concepts.
Classification Schedules (DDC, LCC, UDC)	Used to assign class numbers after identifying subjects.
Online Catalogues (e.g., WorldCat)	Used for reference and cross-checking subject treatment in other libraries.

Example of Subject Analysis

Let's illustrate with a few examples:

Example 1

Title: *The Use of Artificial Intelligence in Library Services*

Main Subject: Artificial Intelligence in Libraries

Broader Term: Library Automation

DDC Class Number: 025.3

Example 2

Title: *History of Yoruba Traditional Religion*

Main Subject: Yoruba Traditional Religion

Broader Term: African Religion

DDC Class Number: 299.6

Example 3

Title: *Information Literacy Skills of Undergraduate Students in Nigerian Universities*

Main Subject: Information Literacy

Related Subject: Higher Education, Nigeria

DDC Class Number: 028.70711

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Challenges of Subject Analysis

Despite its importance, subject analysis can be challenging. Some common difficulties include:

1. **Ambiguous Titles:** Some titles do not clearly indicate the main subject.
2. **Multidisciplinary Topics:** Documents covering several fields may be hard to categorise.
3. **Limited Knowledge:** The cataloguer may lack expertise in the subject area.
4. **Inconsistent Terminology:** Different authors use varying terms for the same concept.
5. **Cultural and Regional Differences:** Some subjects may have no direct equivalent in the classification scheme (common with African topics).